



Rescue drone recognition

Rescue drones are being trained to be able to distinguish between survivors and victims in disaster zones. <https://digit.in/nov19-75>



Gravity waves in the sky

Satellites have captured rare images of atmospheric gravity waves, visible in the clouds. <https://digit.in/nov19-76>

Noise Shots X-Buds

Feature-laden and affordable

Audio startup, Noise, refreshed its line of wireless earphones with the launch of the Noise Shots X-Buds. Let's delve into how the newest Noise buds fare in our review.

Build and design

Upon unboxing the Noise Shots X-Buds, users will be greeted by the earphones encased in a matte-black elliptical charging case, a micro-USB charging cable, and additional ear tips in different sizes (S, M and L). The oval charging case's matte finish is pleasing to the touch and feels quite good in hand. It is fairly pocketable and lightweight as well.

The design of the earphones is reminiscent of the Apple AirPods since they too feature the customary 'pipe-style' design with angled tips which provide a snug fit. The Shots X-Buds are comfortable to wear, and stay put even during running and light exercise.

Overall, the design of the charging case and earphones complement each other well, with both sporting a minimalist, understated yet classy look.

Features

The Noise Shots X-Buds come equipped with a plethora of features that are usually given the skip at this price point. They have built-in touch controls which allow you to control the volume, pause/play, skip tracks, launch voice assistant and, accept and reject calls.

Despite the array of touch-enabled controls, we felt that they were somewhat counterintuitive and were put off by some of the odd touch combos needed to perform certain actions. Some of the actions only worked about 50 percent of the time, but we used the pause/play and volume controls extensively since they worked flawlessly.

The Noise Shots X-Buds are also IPX5 rated (sweat-resistant) which



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means that they can brave the occasional light rain and sweat-inducing workout sessions. The earphones sport Bluetooth 5.0 connectivity, auto power, pairing and power

off capabilities, and AAC codec support. However, there is micro-USB charging instead of Type-C, which is something we're always going to complain about.

Performance

Coming to the sound quality, the Noise Shots X-Buds deliver competent sound quality. However, where they do trail behind is the bass response. In tracks such as *Another One Bites the Dust* by Queen or *Uptown Funk* by Bruno Mars and Mark Ronson, the bass thumps are rather muted which makes the entire track feel dynamically flat.

Mids and highs on the Noise Shots X-Buds sound sculpted and full-bodied. While electronic synth bass in *Motherjane's Mindstreet* was slightly muted, most other instruments present in the track were well-represented and well-preserved. The vocals also shine on these earphones, with the sibilant sounds in *Billie Eilish's Bad Guy* sounding crystal clear. The 's' sounds and Billie's sporadic breaths didn't sound harsh or 'hissy'.

In *Dream Theatre's Pull Me Under*, the array of instruments did sound accurate, however, the instrument separation seemed slightly lacking. Spacing between the instruments was also

inefficient which caused them to sound slightly muddled. However, we're being extremely nitpicky here, since sound-stage is never really great in IEMs where the drivers press against your ear canals.

Noise isolation was decent and sound leakage was also minimal. We recorded a mere 50.9dB of leakage in our tests at 65 per cent volume.

Watching Netflix, YouTube and Hotstar was a pleasant experience, and we did not face any major latency issues. We also played COD mobile, and the stereo sound in-game was commendable since we could pinpoint directional footsteps and gunshots. Call quality, on the other hand, is strictly average.

Overall, the sound is detailed in mid-range and treble range, the vocals are clear but the bass is underwhelming, but not completely muted. The Noise Shots X-Buds are better than what you'd expect budget-friendly true wireless earphones to sound.

Battery Life

The Noise Shots X-Buds offers a fairly sizeable four hours of battery life on the earbuds itself and the accompanying charging case is capable of topping the earphones off an additional three times.

We managed to extract about 3 and a half hours of juice from the earbuds and 3 additional charges from the case. It took around 2 hours and 15 minutes to charge the case from 0 to 100 per cent.

Bottomline

There's a lot to like in the Noise Shots X-Buds. At a fairly affordable price of ₹3,999, the earphones offer balanced midrange and treble performance. Bass heads, however, may not find these to their liking. Nevertheless, if the bass-y 'booms' don't matter too much to you, these buds offer commendable sound performance and a ton of features.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

WEIGHT: 49.9 g | BLUETOOTH VERSION: V5.0 | IP RATING: IPX5
Water and Sweat Resistant | CONTROLS: Touch | BATTERY LIFE
(EARPHONES ONLY): 4 hours | BATTERY LIFE (TOTAL): 16 hours
with case | WIRELESS RANGE: 10m

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